

Welcome to IELTS Academic Preparation

Welcome, and thank you for joining us. Most of you are here because a number matters: a band score for a university place, for professional registration, or for a visa application. This course is designed to help you show the English you already have, under exam conditions. Over eight weeks you'll learn exactly how each part of the test works, practice every major question type, write and self-mark both Writing tasks, rehearse the Speaking interview, and sit **two full practice tests** so that nothing on test day is a surprise.

Some of you are engineers, nurses, teachers, or students; some of you have taken IELTS before and some have never seen a test paper. Everyone starts from a different place, and everyone is measured against **their own starting point**, not against the person sitting next to them.

WHEN AND WHERE

 Days:

 Time:

 Place / Room:

 First class:

 Last class:

 My test date (if booked):

 The course runs for **8 weeks**, with **2 classes** a week. Each class lasts **90 minutes**, so there are **16 classes** in total.

 **Class 1** is an orientation and a short **diagnostic** (a little Listening and Reading, a writing sample, and a three-minute speaking sample), so we know where each of you is starting. **Class 8** is **Practice Test 1** (timed Listening and Reading). **Classes 15 and 16** are **Practice Test 2**: Listening and Reading first, then Writing and a short speaking interview, followed by a band debrief and a celebration. 

WHAT TO BRING



a notebook



a pencil
and an eraser



your phone
(for recording; on silent)



water
(if you like)

 Your teacher will give you a **workbook** and a **band tracker**. Please bring both to **every** class. We practice with a **pencil** because the paper-based test uses one. If you have a simple watch, bring it too: learning to pace yourself without your phone is part of the training. We also recommend an **error log**, a page at the back of your notebook where you record every mistake from practice and the reason for it. By week 8 it will be the most useful thing you own.

HOW OUR CLASS WORKS



Please arrive **on time**. Classes start with a short warm-up, and some classes start with a timed task.



Keep your phone **on silent**. We use phones only to record speaking practice and to time ourselves.



Feedback is always linked to the **band criteria**, so you know exactly which criterion a comment affects and what to do next.



Your scores are **private**. You decide whether to share them. We compare you with yourself, never with a classmate.



If you can't come, please **let your teacher know**, and do the online lesson at home.



Your personal story is **yours**. In speaking practice you can always use a real or an imagined example. Examiners mark your English, not your life.

WHEN THE CLOCK IS RUNNING

Many classes include **timed practice**, and three classes are full test sessions. These ground rules keep the room fair and calm for everyone, and they are close to the rules of the real test:



Silence once the clock starts. If you need something, raise your hand and wait for your teacher.



Phones face down and away, and no dictionaries or translation apps during timed work.



Pencils down when time is called, even in the middle of a sentence. Honest timing gives you an honest result.



Finished early? Check your spelling, your word limits, and any blanks. Stay quiet until everyone has finished.



Never leave a blank. A wrong answer loses nothing, so an educated guess is always worth writing.



Mark honestly. When we self-mark, a generous score today only hides the problem we need to fix before test day.



USEFUL PHRASES FOR CLASS

ASKING ABOUT THE TEST



Would this answer be accepted if I spelled it ____?



Does "____" count as one word or two?



Which criterion does this mistake affect?



What would make this a band ____ answer?

IN SPEAKING PRACTICE



Sorry, could you repeat the question, please?



That's an interesting question. Let me think...



The main reason is ... For example, ...



Could I have a moment to collect my thoughts?

IELTS Academic Preparation: free

Each of the **12 lessons** taught in class has a matching **online lesson** with the strategies, question types, annotated model answers, and exercises with answers. It's your homework, and it lets you catch up if you miss a class. It works on a phone, a tablet, or a computer.

rays-esl.netlify.app/curriculum-ielts/

- 1 Open the website, or scan the QR code with your phone camera.

- 2 Choose the lesson your teacher gives you (for example, **Lesson 2.3**).
- 3 Press the  buttons to hear the model sentences. Then **shadow** them: say each line along with the audio, copying its stress, rhythm, and pausing. (No sound? Turn up the volume, or try the Chrome browser. The  Audio control lets you choose a US or UK voice and slow it down.)
- 4 Do the exercises **before** you open the answers, then the lesson task. Time yourself whenever the task says so, and write your result on your band tracker.



Scan me 

 Aim for **45–60 minutes, 2–3 times** a week, plus **15 minutes of English every day**: a news article or a science feature, a podcast or a lecture, or one paragraph of writing.

The online lessons and our classroom materials both use American English (*practice, analyze, center, program*). IELTS accepts American **or** British spelling; the important thing is to **choose one and use it consistently** in a piece of writing.

Translation help and more practice

This free page shows you how to **translate** a lesson into your language, and it lists free tools for listening, pronunciation, and speaking practice.

`rays-esl.netlify.app/curriculum/learning-tools.html`

For IELTS, work in **English first** and use translation only to check an instruction or a subtle word. For listening practice, choose lectures, science programs, and podcasts about education, health, technology, and the environment, with **English** subtitles or none at all.



Scan me 

What to expect: honest numbers

We want you to plan with real information, so here it is:

- With regular homework, a gain of about **half a band** over eight weeks is common. Some learners gain more, especially when their main problem was **technique** (timing, word limits, the Writing task structure). A bigger jump is possible, but it is **not guaranteed**, and anyone who promises one is guessing.
- Progress is usually **uneven**. Listening and Reading often move first; Writing and Speaking usually move more slowly because they depend on habits built over time.
- Scores sometimes **dip** for a week or two while you change your technique. That is normal, and it usually comes before a gain.
- Our practice-test bands are **estimates**. They are useful for planning, but only the official test gives an official score.
- If the gap between your diagnostic band and your target is large, your teacher will talk with you privately about a **realistic test date**, or about a general English course first. That is advice, not a judgment.

KEEPING TEST NERVES UNDER CONTROL

Almost everyone feels nervous about a test that matters this much. A little tension helps you focus; too much steals your technique. These habits help:

Practice under real conditions.

The more timed tests you sit here, the more ordinary the real one will feel.

Breathe slowly before each section.

Breathe in for four counts and out for six, three times. It really does slow your heart rate.

Let one question go.

Missed an answer in Listening? Leave it and catch the next one. One mark is only one mark.

Speaking is a conversation.

The examiner wants you to talk. If you lose a word, describe it and keep going.

Sleep beats cramming.

In the last few days, light review and a good night's sleep will help you more than new material.

Talk to your teacher.

If worry is affecting your sleep or your practice, tell us. You are not the first, and we can help you plan.



BOOKING THE OFFICIAL TEST

- ◆ **Check your requirement first.** Ask your university, registration body, or immigration adviser for the exact score: the overall band **and** any minimum for each skill (for example, "6.5 overall, no skill below 6.0").
- ◆ **Choose the right version.** This course prepares you for **IELTS Academic**. Some visa and work routes ask for General Training instead, so check before you book.
- ◆ **Book only through the official IELTS website or an authorized test center.** You can usually choose a paper-based or computer-delivered test; the content and scoring are the same. Book early, because popular dates fill up.
- ◆ **Use the same ID** to book and on test day, usually a passport. Check the name and date of birth carefully.
- ◆ **Be careful of scams.** Nobody can sell you a guaranteed band or a certificate without the test. If an offer sounds too good to be true, it is.

This course is independent. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by the IELTS partners, and fees, dates, and rules are set by them, so always check the official information before you book.



My teacher

Name:



Phone / text:



Email:

Other help:



Can't come to class? Send a short message: "Hi, this is _____. I'm afraid I won't be able to make it today because _____. I'll do the online lesson at home before the next class." If you miss a practice test class, ask your teacher how to sit it at home under timed conditions.



YOU'RE READY TO START

IELTS is a skill you can train, not a verdict on you as a person or on your intelligence. Much of the progress in the next eight weeks will come from **knowing the test**: where the marks are, where the traps are, and how to use every minute. The rest will come from steady, honest practice. You don't need to feel confident to begin. Confidence is what you build, one timed task at a time. We're glad you're here. Welcome.